BOOKS ▼

The Forest for the Trees

A new anthology, edited by ARUPJYOTI SAIKIA and MAHESH RANGARAJAN, offers a reappraisal of Indian forests, from prehistory to the present, by leading scholars

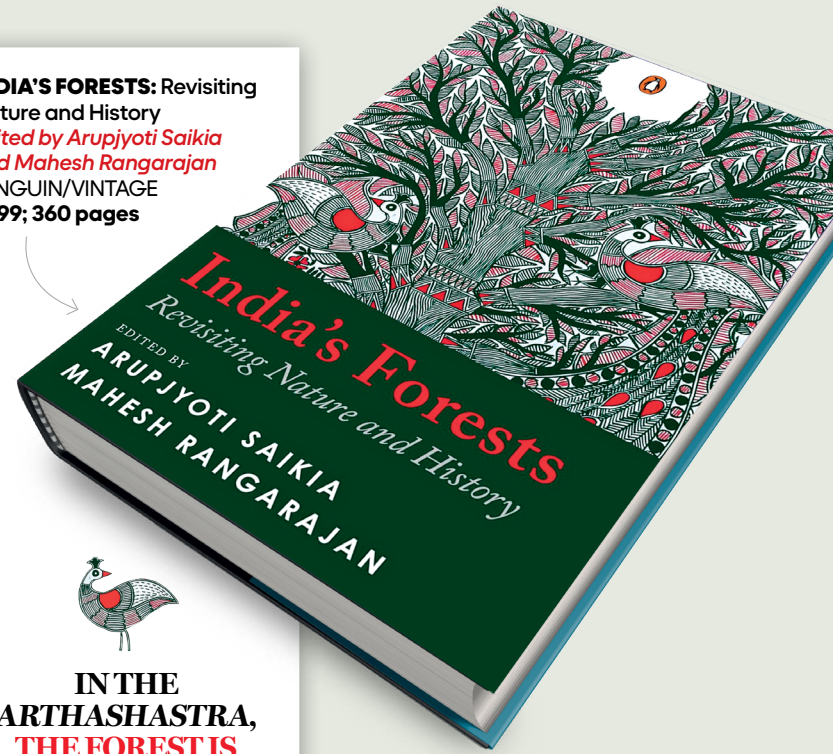
Reading *India's Forests* along the arc of *The Unquiet Woods*, Ramachandra Guha's seminal history of the Chipko protest, and the late ecologist Madhav Gadgil's memoir, *A Walk up the Hill*, evokes a sense of continuity. Edited by Arupjyoti Saikia and Mahesh Rangarajan, this anthology of essays examines the forest as a repository of memory, wealth, tradition, lore and biodiversity, all the while reiterating the question: what are forests for?

The utility of forests is a problem that occupied the Indian imagination millennia before the bulldozer brought it down to a day's work. The foreword equates forests to green glaciers: both are receding. Like glaciers, forests modulate climate—subcontinental forests directly influence the South Asian monsoon. More visibly, they are disappearing in real time, usurped by urbanisation, industrial expansion and land grab, pressures accentuated by liberalisation.

The anthology's historical reach is long. Kumkum Roy reads the *Arthashastra* as a document of fiscal imagination: the forest catalogued for its taxable yield—hides, tusks, roots, flowers, herbs—two millennia before the forest department existed. Upinder Singh reinforces this: forests were not on the margins of the state but within its ambit. Aloka Parasher Sen examines the *upavanam*, a cultivated medicinal garden that complicates the idea of what is 'wild'. Shibani Roy challenges the fantasy of the pristine forest in the Indo-Gangetic plain. The colonial rupture—the Forest Department in 1864, the Forest Act of 1878—converted forests from a commons to a managed resource, a transition Guha recorded lucidly.

Hunting by rulers recurs as a theme, from caracals and the now-extinct cheetah to the

INDIA'S FORESTS: Revisiting Nature and History
Edited by Arupjyoti Saikia and Mahesh Rangarajan
PENGUIN/VINTAGE
₹999; 360 pages



IN THE *ARTHASHASTRA*, THE FOREST IS CATALOGUED FOR ITS TAXABLE YIELD—TWO MILLENNIA BEFORE THE FOREST DEPARTMENT EXISTED